Teaching Philosophy

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In my time as a student, the most impactful learning experiences weren't when I could repeat steps to solve a problem, but when I had mastered the logic of the topic deeply enough to solve any problem without the need for pre-rendered steps. It's that moment—the lightbulb turning on, the connection forming between previously disconnected ideas—that has shaped how I think about teaching. I believe that true learning occurs when students move beyond rote memorization into the territory of connection-building: weaving a web of meaning that bridges concepts, experiences, and questions. As an educator, my goal is to create environments where this kind of understanding can flourish.

At its core, learning is the process of forming durable mental connections—what I think of as cognitive pathways—between concepts. These connections are not created in isolation; they emerge when students are given space to question, explore, and make mistakes. Teaching, then, is about curating those spaces. My role is not to simply deliver content, but to guide students in constructing these webs of understanding by asking better questions, drawing connections between ideas, and encouraging them to do the same.

This belief in connection-building stems in part from my training as an economist, where we're taught to think in systems. A small change to one market may result in large reverberations across many markets. I strive to ensure that my teaching philosophy, while informed by economic thinking, remains broadly applicable. The act of teaching is fundamentally an act of translation: making abstract ideas legible and relevant to diverse learners. Whether one is teaching economics or art, the aim is to help students see how the tools we learn are not ends in themselves, but ways of understanding the world more deeply.

Students do not come to the classroom as blank slates. They bring with them unique prior knowledge, goals, anxieties, and strengths. I see the student's role not as a passive receiver of information, but as an active constructor of knowledge. My job is to design learning environments that honor and leverage those differences. This means tailoring content delivery so students can frame new ideas through their own life experiences—connecting lessons to what they already care about and understand. To support this, I use varied formats—videos, readings, discussions, interactive tools—and embed regular opportunities for students to apply, discuss, and reflect on what they're learning.

Mistakes are not setbacks; they are sparks for growth. I believe that some of the greatest successes are built on small failures. The fear of being wrong too often stifles creativity and curiosity, so I strive to create a culture where risk-taking is encouraged. Asking the so-called "dumb question" is often the moment that unlocks a deeper insight—not just for the student asking, but for the entire class. This means building a classroom environment where experimentation is rewarded and students are not penalized for being imperfect in the learning process.

In practice, I structure class time around hands-on, active engagement. I use demonstrations, case discussions, collaborative problem-solving, and low-stakes practice opportunities. These activities are deliberately designed to help students recall and reapply prior knowledge, which research shows is essential to forming lasting cognitive pathways. But more than that, I aim to make the classroom dynamic and enjoyable. Games, multimedia, peer instruction, and creative challenges not only make learning more engaging—they also help students connect to the material in different ways, reaching them through varied cognitive and emotional channels.

High-stakes assessments may be necessary in some courses, but I emphasize frequent, formative feedback that supports growth without fear. I also devote time to building community: checking in on students' well-being, creating moments of levity, and showing that curiosity is always welcome. A relaxed and enthusiastic classroom culture promotes a sense of safety and shared purpose, where students feel comfortable contributing and invested in their learning.

Teaching is also an act of learning. Some of the most successful educators I've encountered are those who are still discovering new ideas in the topics they've taught for decades through the act of teaching itself. I frequently hear anecdotes of influential professors finding research topics by simply contemplating new methods for instruction. The mindset of teaching as a source of intellectual discovery is the beauty of the academic profession and is something I am always conscious of emulating. I regularly revisit my course structure, reflect on what did or didn't work, and look for ways to better support all learners. No two students are alike, and part of what excites me about teaching is the ongoing challenge of meeting students where they are while guiding them to where they can go.

To me, being an effective teacher means being a thoughtful designer, a patient coach, and a reflective learner. It means leading with empathy and ending each class having learned something new myself. My goal is not only to help students understand a subject, but to help them become more confident, curious thinkers. In that sense, teaching is not just about building knowledge—it's about building the capacity to learn.

In summary, my teaching philosophy centers on connection: between concepts, between students and ideas, and between students and their lived experiences. I believe in a classroom where small failures are stepping stones to mastery, where engagement is sparked by creativity and mutual respect, and where teaching is as much about listening as it is about speaking. If students leave my course with more curiosity, more confidence, and more clarity—not just about the material, but about their ability to learn—then I will consider myself successful as an educator.